

Husserl's phenomenology

Kierkegaard and Nietzsche in their different ways each explored subjective experience in terms of the freedom to make moral decisions to give meaning to life. Edmund Husserl took a more systematic approach, taking the ideas of Kant as a starting point. Kant had shown that we can have no apprehension of things-in-themselves (see [Phenomenon and noumenon](#)), but Husserl felt philosophy had become distracted by unanswerable questions about that noumenal world. He suggested we should put these to one side to concentrate on the 'phenomenal' world that we experience. This approach, known as phenomenology, 'puts in brackets' the problem of the independent existence of our objects of awareness and examines instead the only things we can be sure of knowing. Husserl called this the *Lebenswelt* ('life's world'). By treating all the objects of our experience as phenomena, and ignoring whether they actually exist or not, we can focus our attention on the first-person experience itself, what it means to be having that experience and the nature of our consciousness.

{ Noumena }

(That which we
cannot experience and
cannot apprehend)

Lebenswelt —
the world we
live in

Phenomena
(That which we
experience)